

Psalms 114

When Israel Went Out of Egypt

The sea saw it, and fled: Jordan was driven back

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *When Israel went out of Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of strange language;*
- 2 *Judah was his sanctuary, and Israel his dominion.*
- 3 *The sea saw it, and fled: Jordan was driven back.*
- 4 *The mountains skipped like rams, and the little hills like lambs.*
- 5 *What ailed thee, O thou sea, that thou fleddest? thou Jordan, that thou wast driven back?*
- 6 *Ye mountains, that ye skipped like rams; and ye little hills, like lambs?*
- 7 *Tremble, thou earth, at the presence of the Lord, at the presence of the God of Jacob;*
- 8 *Which turned the rock into a standing water, the flint into a fountain of waters.*

2 · CONTEXT

A brief, vivid retelling of the exodus and the crossing of the Jordan, Psalm 114 personifies nature itself as reacting to God's presence—the sea fleeing, the Jordan turning back, mountains skipping like young animals. Henry reads the psalm's closing question to the sea and mountains ('what ailed thee?') as a deliberate rhetorical device: even inanimate creation is treated as having every reason to tremble before the God who could do such things, which is precisely the point directed at the reader.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

The exodus is recalled plainly: Israel leaving Egypt, the house of Jacob from a people of a foreign language, with Judah becoming God's sanctuary and Israel His dominion—a scattered, enslaved people transformed into God's own possession and dwelling place.

Verse 3-4

Nature itself is pictured reacting: the sea saw it and fled, the Jordan was driven back, mountains skipped like rams and little hills like lambs—the language of terror and celebration applied to geography itself in response to God's presence and power.

Verse 5-6

A direct, almost teasing question is posed to that same nature: what ailed you, sea, that you fled? Jordan, that you turned back? Mountains and hills, that you skipped like rams and lambs? The absurdity of the question underscores how total God's authority over creation actually is.

Verse 7-8

The implied answer arrives as command: tremble, earth, at the presence of the Lord, the God of Jacob, who turned rock into standing water and flint into a fountain—the same power that reshaped the sea and rivers is shown reshaping even the hardest stone into a source of life.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God's presence is powerful enough to make the sea flee and rivers reverse course, and the psalm's playful, almost mocking question to nature ('what ailed thee?') is aimed ultimately at the reader—if mountains have reason to tremble before this God, so does every reader who takes His presence for granted. The same power capable of such dramatic upheaval is also shown turning solid rock into flowing water, provision emerging from the hardest, least likely source.

Application for life today.

Let the psalm's rhetorical question turn back on you: if the sea and mountains have reason to tremble at God's presence, examine where you have grown too casual about that same presence in your own life. Recall a personal 'exodus'—a transformation from bondage to belonging—and let this psalm's vivid imagery give it fresh, concrete language rather than vague summary. When you face something as hard and unyielding as flint, remember verse 8's promise: God can turn even the hardest circumstance into a fountain.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. If the sea and mountains had reason to tremble at God's presence (vv. 3–7), where have you grown too casual or familiar with that same presence in your own life?

2. What personal 'exodus'—a specific transformation from bondage to belonging—could you retell with the vivid, concrete language this psalm gives Israel's story?

3. What current circumstance feels as hard and unyielding as flint (v. 8), and what would it mean to actually expect God to turn it into a fountain?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).